Economic Aspects of Land Reform in Kiangsu, 1949-52

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Introduction

There were various objectives behind the decision of the Chinese Government to launch a land reform movement in 1950. In political terms, it served to eliminate a serious obstacle to the consolidation of its authority by depriving the landlord class of the roots of its power. In economic terms, the redistribution of essential resources (draft animals, seed, tools and buildings as well as land) promised to release rural forces of production. In terms of social welfare, too, the change in land relations was likely to be beneficial if it were accompanied by a more equitable distribution of agricultural output.

Admittedly, land reform was only one stage in a much longer process leading to fully socialist agricultural collectivization. But in the early 1950s this was a distant aim. In any case, if the thesis that China's agricultural stagnation arose primarily from the supposedly "feudal" relationships persisting in the countryside were correct, a radical programme of confiscation and reallocation would presumably be reflected in significant economic and welfare gains.

At the most general level, this two-part article seeks to throw light on these broad issues by examining the implementation of land reform and some of its economic consequences in a single province, Kiangsu. By analysing provincial material, it is hoped to be able to show how the multiple objectives of land reform gave rise to serious policy conflicts – conflicts which were accentuated by the nature of local economic conditions. The documentary evidence of central, regional and provincial directives suggests how the planners approached these problems and the progress of the campaign shows how far the policies embodied in these documents succeeded in obviating them. More quantitative evidence also makes it possible to analyse the economic impact of resource reallocation upon various groups in the peasant economy and thereby indicates the contribution of land reform to overall agricultural growth.

The decision to limit the study to a single province was prompted by the hope that a more informed understanding of early institutional

* This paper constitutes Part 1 of a two-part article, the second instalment of which will be published in the next issue of *The China Quarterly*.

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

change might be obtained by examining a small [1] area in detail. However much of a commonplace, it remains an important truth that China's vast geographical area and consequent regional diversity may make aggregate studies too simplistic and even misleading. There is also of course the obverse danger that no one province will be sufficiently representative to permit any general conclusions to be drawn from its experience. But by reason of the contrasting conditions contained within its boundaries, I believe that Kiangsu is a suitable case for individual treatment.

The narrow geographical focus does not imply comprehensive coverage of every aspect of land reform. As the title of the article indicates, emphasis is placed almost exclusively on the economic implications and, to the extent that the movement was also concerned with facilitating social and political changes, this may seem unduly restrictive.[2] Perhaps a more serious omission is the absence of any discussion of the new tax regulations or of wage trends in the early 1950s. But as I have preferred to concentrate on the productivity and welfare aspects of land reform, lack of time and space have forced me to ignore these issues. Some may also feel that more attention should have been given to analysing the initial socio-economic conditions within which land reform was implemented in Kiangsu and against which its success was partly to be judged. However, this would have resulted in an article even longer and more unwieldy than the present one. In any case, the institutional framework of agriculture in Kiangsu is something that I have analysed at length elsewhere.[3]

The arrangement of the article is simple. In Part I some introductory remarks about land tenure before 1949 and the earliest attempts by the Chinese Communist Party (CCP) to foster agrarian reform are followed by a more extended analysis of national, regional and provincial directives as they affected North and South Kiangsu. This documentary analysis suggests the constraints that local conditions placed on land reform and so indicates some of the factors which threatened to undermine its progress. A chronological account of the

1. That is, "small" in relation to the whole of China. But it is as well to remember that Kiangsu in the early 1950s contained a total population of around 45 millions and had a surface area of more than 100,000 sq. km.

2. For a discussion of some non-economic aspects of land reform, see G. Shillinglaw, "Land reform and peasant mobilization in Southern China, 1947–1950," in D. Lehmann (ed.), *Agrarian Reform and Agrarian Reformism* (London: Faber & Faber, 1974).

3. In a paper to be published by the Contemporary China Institute, S.O.A.S., "Land tenure in pre-revolutionary China: Kiangsu province in the 1920s and 1930s." This survey contains an analysis of many important features of Kiangsu's rural socio-economy before 1949: for example, the nature of landlordism in the province; tenancy systems (including the phenomenon of "permanent" tenancy and the division of land between sub-soil and surface owners); levels of rent; security of tenure and other exploitative aspects. There is also a brief discussion of some of the economic implications of tenancy.

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

process of confiscation and reallocation also serves to indicate some of the difficulties that arose in the formulation and implementation of policy. Part II consists of an assessment of the purely economic implications of land reform in the province. This is viewed in terms of its impact on individual peasants (or groups of peasants) as well as on the broader agricultural economy. From it some conclusions are drawn about the scope of land reform as a vehicle for agricultural development and about the relationship of land reform with subsequent institutional changes.

A few words by way of providing some background information may usefully conclude this brief introduction. Mention has already been made of the contrasting conditions contained within Kiangsu. This was most clearly manifested in the striking economic dichotomy between Kiangpei and Kiangnan.[4] The southern half (especially T'ai Hu) was one of the most fertile agricultural areas of China and crop yields were very high. By contrast, although there were a few pockets of high productivity, the rest of the province was generally poor and underdeveloped. The degree of poverty increased as one moved northwards: in the far north, severely adverse natural conditions kept levels of agricultural output low and unstable.

The richness of Kiangnan was also reflected in its highly developed urban and industrial sectors. Cities such as Shanghai, Nanking, Wusih and Soochow had long been important industrial centres and they continued to expand during the 1950s. The existence of this large urban population had profound implications for the implementation of rural policies, not least because of the close connection between absentee landlords and commercial and industrial enterprises.

In line with the economic division between north and south, the structure and organization of rural society in Kiangsu before 1949 was extremely complex. Owner-occupation and outright tenancy were both well represented and tenurial arrangements of all kinds could be found, ranging from simple share-cropping in the north to cash-rent systems in the south. This socio-economic matrix provided a difficult testing-ground for the land reform policies of the Chinese Government.

Part 1: The Implementation of Land Reform and Associated Problems

1. *The Institutional Framework of Agriculture before 1949*

Land ownership in Kiangsu before 1949 was very unequal. Investigations conducted by the Commission for Rural Rehabilitation in four *hsien* between 1928 and 1933 revealed that well over half of landowners

4. That is, Kiangsu north and south of the Yangtze. This is not just an arbitrary division, for after 1949 Kiangsu was administered as two separate units: the North Kiangsu and South Kiangsu administrative regions. Not until November 1952 was the province re-united. For this reason, each region is considered separately in this article.

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had holdings smaller than 10 *mou* (1·65 acres).[5] By contrast, farms of 15 acres or more were rare. In addition, there were large numbers of landless peasants: in Ch'ang-shu *hsien*, for example, almost eight out of every 10 peasants had no land of their own.[6]

Tenancy was one way of alleviating land hunger and it existed to some extent throughout the province. If anything, it is likely that the proportion of peasants compelled to farm as tenants was increasing during the decades before 1949. As conditions in the rural sector deteriorated, more and more of them sought credit to tide them over their difficulties. In the absence of organized financial institutions, the main source was the local money-lender to whom they " pledged " or " mortgaged " their land in return for a proportion of its value. Failure to repay the loan within a stipulated period often resulted in the peasant forfeiting his ownership rights and becoming an outright tenant or landless labourer.

The pattern of tenancy in Kiangsu was a complex one. In the north it was most prevalent in the coastal areas and the *hsien* bordering the Yangtze. In the central northern area and along the border with Shantung, where natural conditions were poor and communications undeveloped, fewer peasants rented land and owner-occupation was more common.

A high rate of tenancy might have been expected south of the Yangtze. It is true that according to one source, the landlords of this region comprised 2 per cent of the total population and yet owned about 40 per cent of the land.[7] But it would be wrong to conclude that a correspondingly high incidence of tenancy existed throughout the area. On the contrary, regional variations were significant. For example, information published in the early 1930s indicated that the overall average rate of tenancy was only 25·5 per cent and that in 13 out of 24 South Kiangsu *hsien* the proportion of agricultural households farming land as outright tenants was less than 20 per cent.[8] Such low rates of tenancy, apparently at variance with *a priori* reasoning, were in fact the logical product of a set of historical and economic factors peculiar to South Kiangsu. In particular, the process of industrialization and urbanization seems to have attracted wealth away from the purchase of land into more profitable investments in trade, industry and ancillary services.[9]

5. Hsing-cheng-yüan nung-ts'un fu-hsing wei-yüan-hui (The Commission for Rural Rehabilitation of the Executive Yüan), *Chiang-su-sheng nung-ts'un tiao-ch'a (A Rural Survey of Kiangsu Province)* (Shanghai: Commercial Press, 1934), pp. 94–99, 124–34, 170–85 and 207–20. The four *hsien* were P'ei (Hsü-chou special district), Yen-ch'eng (Yen-ch'eng s.d.), Ch'i-tung (Nan-t'ung s.d.) and Ch'ang-shu (Soochow s.d.). 6. *Ibid.* pp. 207–20.

7. P'an Kuang-tan and Ch'üan Wei-t'ien, *Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko fang-wen chi (Investigations into Land Reform in South Kiangsu)* (Peking: San-lien, 1952), p. 2.

8. Bureau of Foreign Trade, Ministry of Industry, *China Industrial Handbooks: Kiangsu* (Shanghai, 1933), pp. 31–33.

9. In general, the rate of profit on renting out land (expressed as a percentage

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The case of Meiji Japan has shown that where landlords are progressive a high rate of tenancy can co-exist with a rapid rate of agricultural growth.[10] However, the evidence for progressive landlords in Kiangsu would appear to be entirely lacking.[11] Their responsibilities were limited to the collection of rents from their tenants and the payment of taxes to the government. The relationship between landlord and tenant was governed by economic, not social (far less ethical) considerations, but economic interest did not extend as far as carrying out land improvements or agricultural investment. The growth of large cities in the south made relations even more remote by increasing the tendency towards absentee landlordism.[12]

Rents in Kiangsu were paid as a fixed amount, in kind or cash, or as a proportion of output. Fixed rents in kind were most common, but cash rents were also frequently found, as might have been expected in a province where a degree of economic modernization had taken place and where economic crops were widely grown. South of the Yangtze a kind of intermediate system existed whereby rent was fixed in kind but could be converted to a cash payment at the discretion of the landlord. Share-cropping was less common, being found mainly in the north where it offered some protection against poor and unstable harvests engendered by adverse natural conditions.

On average, rents in Kiangsu absorbed 40–50 per cent of a tenant's annual production, although there were local variations depending on area, the quality of land and the nature of the rental system. In general, rent levels were higher in the north than in the south, a fact which

of capital invested) was low in China. According to a survey of more than a hundred farms in Anhwei in 1923, the rate of return was as low as 2·5%: J. L. Buck, *Economic and Social Survey of 102 Farms Near Wuhu, Anhwei, China* (December 1923), cited by Chang Chung-li, *The Income of the Chinese Gentry* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1962). In Kiangsu an investigation made by Chang Hsin-i in 1930 ("Some materials on the tenancy problem in China," *T'ung-chi yüeh-pao* (*Statistical Monthly*), Vol. 2, No. 6 (June 1930), pp. 31–32) indicated that cash rent as a proportion of land value in the province ranged from 8·1 to 10·4% for dry-crop land and from 8·1 to 8·7% for paddy land. When costs of rent collection, possible spoilage, the effects of poor harvests and tax payments are taken into account, it is clear that net profit must have been considerably less. But investment in commercial and industrial enterprises offered higher returns as well as a degree of security that did not attach to income from land. Such factors may have reduced the relative attractions of landlordism in South Kiangsu.

10. See K. Ohkawa and H. Rosovsky, "The role of agriculture in modern Japanese economic development," *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, Vol. 9, Part 2 (October 1960), pp. 43–68.

11. Landlords did sometimes provide seeds, fertilizer and other items of working capital, but such help was reflected in the payment of a higher rent.

12. A concomitant of the increase in absentee landlordism in South Kiangsu was the development of institutions known as "landlord bursaries" (*tsu-chan*). These were designed to facilitate the exploitation and management of land and were operated by agents working on behalf of landlords. See Yuji Muramatsu, "A documentary study of Chinese landlordism in the late Ch'ing and the early Republican Kiangnan," *Bulletin of the School of Oriental and African Studies*, Vol. XXIX, Part 3 (1966), pp. 566–99.

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reflected not only different socio-economic conditions but also a perverse relationship between rents and land productivity.[13]

In abstract terms, the welfare implications to an individual peasant of having to hand over 40 per cent or more of his farm output each year are easily appreciated. Attempting to quantify the economic implications is a more difficult task, though an important one if we are to understand the attraction of a programme of land redistribution. In this connection an analysis of the income and expenditure per *mou* of land for a tenant farmer and an owner-cultivator in a district of Wusih *hsien* in the mid-1930s is of special interest.[14] It reveals that rent accounted for 43·45 per cent of the tenant's annual per *mou* expenditure. The only comparable obligation on the owner-cultivator was the payment of taxes, but these absorbed less than 30 per cent of his expenditure. In any case, the absolute sum involved was a mere 0·97 *yüan* per *mou* compared with the rent of 13·13 *yüan*. For both categories income and other costs were the same. When total income was compared with total expenditure, the owner-cultivator emerged with a surplus of 11·19 *yüan* per *mou*, while the tenant suffered a deficit of 0·98 *yüan*. It may be assumed that only the possibility of subsidiary earnings made the tenant's economic position viable.

It is obvious that without the need to pay rent a tenant's ability to undertake net investment would be much improved. This is well brought out in an article comparing expenditure by tenants and owner-cultivators on various items of working capital (tools, fertilizer, draft animals, hired labour) in Ch'i-tung *hsien*.[15] Such expenditures promised to make a significant contribution to increased productivity. Yet only a quarter of the tenant households spent anything on animal husbandry, hired labour and fertilizer purchases,[16] and in every case the average expenditure per tenant household was substantially lower than that of owner-cultivators. Rent and subsistence requirements took 91 per cent of tenants' total household expenditure, leaving a minimal amount

13. The expected direct relationship between soil fertility (quality of land) and rent level does not emerge from available data. Rather there was a tendency for an inverse relationship to exist in Kiangsu: in other words, the burden of rent was heaviest for those least able to bear it. For specific evidence see Chang Yu-i, *Chung-kuo chin-tai nung-yeh shih-tzu-liao* (*Source Materials on Modern Chinese Agricultural History*) (Peking: San-lien, 1957), Vol. 3, p. 247. Also Ch'en Po-ta, *A Study of Land Rent in Pre-Liberation China* (Peking: Foreign Languages Press, 1966), Chap. 3.

14. Wang T'ien-tzu, "The rural economy of Pei-hsia in Wusih," *Nung-hang yüeh-k'an* (*Monthly Journal of the Farmers' Bank of China*), Vol. 2, No. 11 (November 1935), pp. 15–31.

15. Liu Hsiu-ch'ing, "Ch'i-tung tsu-tien wen-t'i yü fu-chih tzu-keng-nung yün-tung" ("The problem of tenancy in Ch'i-tung and the movement to create owner-cultivators"), *Ti-cheng yüeh-k'an* (*Land Administration Monthly*), Vol. 5, Nos. 2 and 3 (March 1937), pp. 321–46.

16. Every one of the owner-cultivator households spent something on hired labour, house repairs and purchases of tools and fertilizers. The proportion carrying out expenditure on animal husbandry was lower at 66·67%. See *ibid.*

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for productive investment (including replacement). But for owner-cultivators the absence of a rent burden not only permitted them to spend more on subsistence but also left them a much larger surplus for production purposes.

Even this brief survey of the institutional framework of agriculture before 1949 is sufficient to show that there was a strong case in favour of some kind of agrarian reform in Kiangsu.[17] Moreover, the one-sidedness of tenurial arrangements ensured that many peasants would respond enthusiastically to a programme which reallocated land to the landless and land-hungry. To the extent that it removed economic constraints imposed by the tenancy system, it could also be expected to have a favourable effect on agricultural efficiency.

But was institutional change enough? Was it sufficient to remove the economic as well as the socio-economic constraints upon production increases? Tenancy was not after all the only obstacle to sustained agricultural growth. The absolute shortage of resources such as tools, draft animals and even labour posed serious problems.[18] Nor was land in unlimited supply, as the characteristically small operational holdings indicated.[19] In such circumstances the effects of reallocation were bound to be limited. All these factors need to be borne in mind when one considers the land reform movement in Kiangsu.

2. *Land Reform in Kiangsu before 1949*

Communist activity in Kiangsu prior to the Sino-Japanese War was notable chiefly for its absence. Peasant agitation and demands for rent reduction did occur and were said to be fostered by the CCP,[20] but these were isolated outbreaks which never developed on a wide scale. In the 1930s suggestions that land should be purchased from landlords and redistributed to poor peasants were also dubbed "communistic" although the connection with the CCP and communist ideology was more imagined than real.[21] It was not until the Sino-

17. Consideration of other factors such as lack of security of tenure in Kiangsu and landlords' use of exploitative devices other than rent would reinforce this conclusion.

18. Buck's data show that there was well under one draft animal unit per farm in his Kiangsu sample. See J. L. Buck, *Land Utilization in China* (Shanghai: Commercial Press, 1937), Statistical Volume, Table 5, p. 131. The supply situation of farm tools was equally serious: most farms probably had a traditional plough and one or two simple tools, but larger and more specialized equipment was often shared.

19. Although the institution of tenancy enabled many landless peasants to obtain a living from the land, the most frequent size of operational holding remained very small. Moreover, most farms were heavily fragmented.

20. See, for example, "Chiang-su I-hsing ti nung-ts'un ching-chi yü kung-ch'an-tang pao-tung ti chen-hsiang" ("The rural economy of I-hsing and the Communist Party movement"), *Ts'un-chih* (*Rural Administration*), Vol. 2, Nos. 11 and 12, pp. 40–46.

21. See Liu, "The problem of tenancy."

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Japanese War that the Communist Party began to operate on any scale in the province. In this connection, the most significant event was the retreat of communist guerrilla forces across the Yangtze in 1940: soon afterwards North Kiangsu became an important CCP base and remained such after the defeat of the Japanese in 1945.[22]

During the war years agrarian reform in North Kiangsu followed the relatively moderate policy of "double reduction" that was being pursued elsewhere in China.[23] Its success was said to be reflected in increased production, improved rural living standards and a stronger, more unified, anti-Japanese front.[24] As early as 1944 an investigation of 431 *hsiang* in five *hsien* in the Yen-ch'eng – Fou-ning region revealed an increase in middle peasant numbers at the expense of a decline in those of poor peasant and landlord households.[25] To the extent that landlords were non-productive (even counter-productive) elements in rural society, a fall in their numbers was to be reckoned an economic gain. Poor peasants were by definition those farmers who lacked land and essential working capital and who were therefore a depressing influence on the agricultural sector. Their declining importance could only be a reflection of the increasing importance of other more productive groups (in this case, middle peasants).

For the war years as a whole, a survey of 2,500 households in 11 *hsien* in "Central Kiangsu"[26] showed the following percentage changes in the composition of rural society between 1939 and 1945:

Table: **Changes in the Relative Importance of Various Rural Classes in North Kiangsu between 1939 and 1945**

	As % of rural population		*% change*
	1939	1945	
Hired agricultural labourers	3·24	2·44	−24·69
Poor peasants	46·75	33·39	−28·58
Middle peasants	32·07	41·79	+30·31
(Rich peasants)	(13·69)	(19·03)	(+39·01)
Landlords	4·25	3·35	−21·18

Note: The figures for rich peasants are obtained by deducting the total for the other four categories from 100.

Source: "Land relations in North Kiangsu."

22. For an account of CCP activities in Kiangsu during the Sino-Japanese War, see Chalmers A. Johnson, *Peasant Nationalism and Communist Power: The Emergence of Revolutionary China, 1937–1945* (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 1963), especially Chap. 5.

23. After the outbreak of the Sino-Japanese War in 1937 the CCP modified its agrarian policies in the interest of ostensible national unity against Japan. The compromise policy which emerged was the "double reduction": the reduction of rents by 25% and of interest payments on loans (to 1·0 or 1·5% a month).

24. "Su-pei t'u-ti kuan-hsi ti chin-hsi" ("Land relations in North Kiangsu now and in the past"), *Su-pei jih-pao* (*North Kiangsu Daily*) (*Su-pei*) (Yang-chou), 30 June 1951, p. 4.

25. *Ibid.*

26. Because of the difficulties of unified organization in wartime conditions,

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If these data are to be believed, important changes in the class composition of rural society were taking place – changes which from an economic point of view were clearly desirable. Middle peasants were replacing poor peasants to become the most important class (numerically) in the countryside, while the numbers of hired agricultural labourers, poor peasants and landlords were all falling. Significant too was the increased importance of rich peasants, although it is revealing that their changing status was ignored in the source.

However, it would be easy to exaggerate the significance of these figures. CCP control was not equally firm in all areas and there were parts of North Kiangsu where agrarian reform policies were carried out much less thoroughly or even not at all. In addition, rent and interest reduction often met with the determined opposition of the landlord class, which used various methods ranging from mere cunning to open sabotage to prevent their implementation.[27] In these circumstances poor peasants were frequently unwilling to give active support to the CCP and special organizations were set up to mobilize them against the recalcitrant landlords. The most important of these, the Peasants' National Salvation Association and Rent Investigation Corps,[28] were the forerunners of the Peasant Associations of the 1950s and fulfilled many of the same roles.

After the surrender of the Japanese the latent conflict between the Kuomintang and Chinese Communist armies erupted into civil war, and in the summer of 1946 the communist-held areas of North Kiangsu came under attack. The changed situation was evidenced in parts of North Kiangsu by the substitution of outright land confiscation and redistribution for the earlier more moderate policies of rent and interest reduction. The chronology of events during the post-war years is confused, although it seems reasonable to suppose that the pattern which occurred elsewhere in China was repeated in North Kiangsu.[29]

North Kiangsu was divided into two sub-units, Central and North Kiangsu. The dividing line was the Hwai River.

27. A good account of some of the stratagems resorted to by landlords is given by Lu Feng in his *Jen-min fan-shen chi* (*The People Throw Off their Feudal Yoke*) (Yangtze Publishing House, 1947).

28. Nung-min chiu-kuo hui (abbreviated to Nung-chiu hui) and Ch'a-tsu t'uan.

29. After the end of the Sino-Japanese War peasants began to move spontaneously beyond rent reduction to actual confiscation of landlords' property. In May 1946, under the pressure of events, the Central Committee of the CCP gave its formal approval to these confiscatory actions against landlords, though adding a qualification that moderation should be shown to those having industrial and commercial interests and to the rich peasants. But the last six months of 1946 and much of 1947 was a period when many peasants and cadres ignored the directives issued by the Party and when, as Liu Shao-ch'i later confessed, ". . . most of the deviations in the implementation of agrarian reform were committed . . . and the interests of part of the middle peasants were encroached upon, industry and commerce in the rural areas were partly impaired and indiscriminate beatings and killings occurred . . .": see Liu Shao-ch'i, "On the Agrarian Reform Law,"

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In any case, " double reduction " was now replaced by the policy of giving " land to the tiller." [30]

Between the summer of 1946 and autumn of 1947 deviations from the official line were most serious. It may be assumed that the violence observable elsewhere in China also occurred in North Kiangsu. Certainly, documentary evidence points to this having been a period of fierce conflict. Contemporary reports speak of the communist-held areas in the north of the province launching a struggle with " gun in one hand, abacus in the other " [31] against the landlords, and of bitter confrontations between landlords and tenants.

The situation was in fact a complicated one. In some areas, where the supremacy of the CCP had remained unchallenged, land had been confiscated and reallocated and a new pattern of class relations was already emerging. Elsewhere rent reductions had been reversed after re-occupation by the Kuomintang forces and despite the re-establishment of CCP control " . . . land relations remained confused." [32] Finally, there were areas which had always been in Kuomintang hands and where land reform had never been carried out. Here landlords continued to collect high rents and concentration in landownership was still in evidence. The only quantitative indication of the extent of the pre-1949 agrarian reforms in Kiangsu is a statement that between 1946 and 1949 an area containing four million peasants had fully implemented land reform in North Kiangsu.[33] This figure suggests the magnitude of the achievements of these years, for it indicates that even before Kiangsu was wholly under CCP control, over 20 per cent of North Kiangsu's rural population had experienced land reform.

In the late 1940s South Kiangsu fell rapidly to the Chinese Communist forces. By November 1948 CCP control in China extended to the northern banks of the Yangtze. In April 1949 the armies crossed the river and occupied Nanking. On 27 May Shanghai fell and by 2 June 1949 the whole of the province was in the hands of the CCP.

a report made at the Second Session of the National Committee of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference in Peking, 14 June 1950, and translated in full in *The Agrarian Reform Law of the People's Republic of China and Other Relevant Documents* (Peking: Foreign Languages Press, December 1950).

30. *Keng-che yu ch'i-t'ien.* The original phrase was Sun Yat-sen's, but it was subsequently adopted by the CCP and incorporated into its agrarian programme.

31. " Land relations in North Kiangsu." The Chinese phrase is *i-shou na chiang, i-shou na suan-p'an.*

32. *Ibid.* See also " T'u-ti kai-ko shih-shih pan-fa " (" Methods of implementing land reform "), *Hsin-hua jih-pao* (*New China Daily*) (*Hsin-hua*) (Nanking), 27 November 1950, p. 1, which describes these areas as where " . . . land was distributed during the war of liberation, but was subsequently snatched back by landlords and rich peasants."

33. Kao Feng (vice-chairman of the Land Reform Committee of the People's Administration of North Kiangsu), " Su-pei-ch'ü i-nien-lai t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung ti pao-kao " (" Report on land reform work in North Kiangsu during the past year "), *Su-pei*, 28 December 1951, p. 1.

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3. *Land Reform in the 1950s: The Directives of the Central Government and the East China Military Administration* [34]

The theoretical framework within which land reform took place in Kiangsu was provided by the Agrarian Reform Law of the People's Republic of China,[35] promulgated by the central government on 30 June 1950. It provided for the confiscation and requisition [36] of rented land and other property belonging to landlords, and of land owned by rich peasants in excess of that which they cultivated themselves or with the help of hired labour. The confiscated land and resources were to be distributed to local peasants with " little or no land " of their own.[37] Consideration was also given to the mechanism for implementation and the treatment of special land problems.[38]

Almost simultaneously other laws were passed to ensure the smooth working of the Agrarian Reform Law: for example, the General Regulations Governing the Organization of Peasant Associations and Decisions Concerning the Differentiation of Class Status in the Countryside,[39] both promulgated in the summer of 1950. Directives on land reform were also issued in the large administrative regions of China, as well as at lower levels. Thus, as early as February 1950 the Committee of the East China Military Administration (ECMA) [40] enacted provisions for rent reduction in the " newly liberated " areas of East China.[41] This was the first document that was specifically concerned with the agrarian programme in Kiangsu.

34. The directives considered in this section, together with their dates of publication and/or promulgation, are as follows. *Central Government*: Agrarian Reform Law, 30 June 1950 (promulgated). *East China Military Administration*: Provisions for Rent Reduction in the Newly Liberated Regions of East China, 6 February 1950 (promulgated), 27 April 1950 (published); Directive on Preparatory Work for Land Reform, 21 March 1950 (published); On Agricultural Production Policies in the Land Reform Areas This Autumn and Winter, 18 September 1950 (published); Methods of Implementing Land Reform in East China, 26 November 1950 (published); and On Completing Land Reform Ahead of Time, 5 December 1950 (promulgated).

35. *The Agrarian Reform Law of the People's Republic of China and Other Relevant Documents*, pp. 1–16.

36. In practical terms there seems to have been no difference between these terms: confiscation applied to land belonging to landlords and requisition to that of rich peasants.

37. *Agrarian Reform Law*, p. 4.

38. For a more extended analysis of the provisions of the Agrarian Reform Law, see John Wong, *Land Reform in the People's Republic of China* (New York: Praeger, 1973), Chap. 3.

39. *Agrarian Reform Law*, pp. 17–58.

40. The ECMA was set up on 27 January 1950 in Shanghai. It exercised jurisdiction over the three provinces of Shantung, Chekiang and Fukien; the four administrative districts of North and South Anhwei and North and South Kiangsu; and two municipalities, Shanghai and Nanking.

41. By this time rent reduction had been incorporated into the " Common Programme " as an essential pre-condition of the implementation of land reform in the newly liberated regions. The text of the regulations can be found in " Hsin-ch'ü nung-ts'un mieh-tsu t'iao-li," *Su-nan jih-pao* (*South Kiangsu Daily*) (*Su-nan*) (Wusih), 29 April 1950, p. 1.

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To some extent the provisions were a return to the principles advocated before 1949. Rents were to be reduced by 25 or 30 per cent and a rent ceiling of 35 per cent of the output of the main crop in a "normal" year was imposed. Advance payment of rent and other exploitative devices were abolished. All debts between peasants and landlords or "old-style" rich peasants incurred before 1949 were annulled. Other sections dealt with the distribution of supplementary crops and the question of exemption from rent reduction for certain categories of rentiers such as workers, revolutionaries, widows and orphans.

But there were other ways in which the regulations struck a new and surprising note. For example, despite the clear intention of reducing the exploitation which resulted from the tenancy system, any hint of extreme anti-landlord sentiment was entirely absent from the document. Indeed, Article Two emphasized the continuing ownership rights of the landlords after rent reduction and the legal obligation of tenants to pay rent. Land belonging to landlords who had fled their villages was to be leased out for them *in absentia* by the *hsien* authorities and the rent (appropriately reduced) retained until their return.[42] Clearly it was hoped that alienation could be avoided and rent reduction carried out as smoothly as possible.[43]

The first indication of a time-table for land reform in East China was given in an ECMA directive published in March 1950.[44] It stated that where preparations had been completed, the confiscation and reallocation of land could begin after the 1950 autumn harvest. Elsewhere it was to be delayed until late 1951 or even 1952. As my later analysis will show, in the context of what actually happened, the emphasis on a relatively long time-span at this stage was noteworthy.

One of the preoccupations of the planners throughout the land reform campaign was to ensure that production activities were not impeded by the institutional changes that were taking place. In 1950 this was a particularly important consideration, for natural disasters had badly affected harvests in many parts of East China. In South

42. *Ibid.*

43. A speech made on the same day that the East China regulations were passed reinforced this point by emphasizing that questions involving rent deposits, unpaid hired labourers, the maintenance of tenant security were to be deliberately shelved until land reform "proper" was implemented. See "Kuan-yü Hua-tung hsin chieh-fang ch'ü nung-ts'un mieh-tsu t'iao-li ti shuo-ming" ("Explanation of rent reduction regulations in the villages of the newly liberated areas of East China"), *Hsin Soo-chou pao* (*New Soochow Daily*), 28 April 1950, p. 1. The moderate tone of these documents was echoed in a central directive issued on 18 February 1950, On Land Reform and Public Grain Acquisition in the Newly Liberated Areas.

44. Directive by the East China Military Administrative Committee on Preparatory Work for Land Reform, in *Hua-tung ch'ü ts'ai-cheng ching-chi fa-ling hui-pien* (*Economic and Financial Regulations for the East China Region*) (Shanghai: East China People's Publishing House, 1951), Vol. 2, pp. 1972–976.

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

Kiangsu more than four million *mou* were flooded [45] and in the north, 17 million *mou* (with the consequent loss of 1,000 million *chin* of food grains).[46] In these circumstances the March directive emphasized the critical importance of the spring period for agricultural operations and the need for the closest co-ordination between production-relief work and land reform preparations.

This preparatory work included investigating local conditions, training cadres and spreading the agrarian policies to all classes of rural society. Only when this had been completed could representative experiments take place.[47] The legal rights of landlords were re-affirmed, although it may be significant that a warning was also issued against illegal activities such as land transfers or the deliberate destruction of property.

The next ECMA directive did not appear until September 1950.[48] Though short, it is of the greatest interest, for it provides the first hint of difficulties that had been experienced in the early stages of land reform. It revealed, for example, that because of uncertainty about the amount of land they would receive through redistribution many peasants were letting their agricultural work lapse, and in some places even ceasing to cultivate their land at all. The logic of their behaviour was clear: if the land which they tilled was subsequently reallocated together with its output to another peasant, their original efforts would have benefited them not at all. In order to counter the disincentive effects upon agricultural production, specific provisions were now set down to guarantee that every peasant received the output of the land he farmed.[49]

The rules governing confiscation and reallocation of resources in East China appeared in November 1950 [50] and it is to these that we

45. "Chieh-fang i-lai ti Su-nan nung-min yün-tung kai-k'uang" ("The peasant movement in South Kiangsu since Liberation"), *Su-nan*, 8 February 1950, p. 2.

46. "Su-pei ti tsai-ch'ing yü chiu-tsai kung-tso" ("The situation in North Kiangsu and relief work"), *Hsin Soo-chou pao*, 23 April 1950, p. 4. Also "Su-pei i-nien-lai cheng-fu kung-tso pao-kao" ("Report of government work in North Kiangsu in the past year"), *Su-pei*, 29 October 1950, states that the natural disasters were the worst in many decades. Famine conditions were said to have lasted for more than 10 months and to have affected four million peasants. (One *chin* is approximately 0·5 kg.)

47. At provincial, special district and *hsien* levels.

48. On Agricultural Production Policies in the Land Reform Areas This Autumn and Winter (published 18 September 1950). See *Ts'ai-cheng ching-chi fa-ling hui-pien*, Vol. 2, p. 2000.

49. This was to be achieved in the areas where land reform was to be implemented through the following principles: (1) cultivation of autumn and winter crops should continue on the principle of "he who reaps, tills"; (2) crops could be divided between the original cultivator and the new landowner by the agreement of both parties according to the norms laid down in the rent reduction regulations; (3) the new landowner could reimburse the original cultivator for the total cost of cultivation and fertilizer application carried out before the land was reallocated.

50. *Ts'ai-cheng ching-chi fa-ling hui-pien*, Vol. 2, pp. 1976–996.

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

should now turn. In some respects, the policies the directive set out merely followed the provisions of the Agrarian Reform Law; but in others, through different emphasis or the amplification of certain aspects of the parent law, it assumed an identity of its own.

A serious dilemma which faced the CCP during land reform arose out of the conflicting aims of pursuing the confiscatory policies while protecting industry and trade. The need to ensure the minimum disruption of the modern sector meant that land reform had to be implemented without affecting landlords' participation in industrial and commercial enterprises. Attention had already been drawn to this problem in earlier documents [51] and as was to be expected in a region where the industrial and urban sectors were highly developed, it continued to occupy an important place in the latest East China regulations. Of special interest was the way in which they qualified the general rule that village resources owned by landlords should be subject to confiscation. For example, draft animals used for handicraft production or transport were to be left untouched and only those tools used specifically in agricultural work were to be taken. The same distinction between agricultural and non-agricultural employment as a criterion for confiscation was applied to surplus buildings belonging to landlords. And of course it was stipulated that no landlord property in the cities should be made available for redistribution.

If the landlords held a key position vis-à-vis industry and trade, within the agricultural sector itself one of the most sensitive problems concerned the status of rich peasants. The economic role of this group was of crucial importance. Their relatively advanced capital base (at least when compared with that of the poor and middle peasants) tended to make them the most efficient farmers and even enabled them to undertake net investment. At the same time, their larger-than-average holdings and the fact that some of them rented out land made them an obvious target in any land reform programme. However, their potential contribution to agricultural growth was too great to ignore and, accordingly, after 1949 CCP policy emphasized the need to "preserve the rich peasant economy." [52] Thus, Article Six of the Agrarian Reform Law called for the protection of ". . . land owned by rich peasants and cultivated by themselves or by hired labour . . ." [53] and even permitted rich peasants to continue renting out small amounts of land. Although this broad policy was echoed by the ECMA, it is worth comparing the passages dealing with the treatment of rich peasants in the two documents, for their different wording suggests a change in emphasis whose significance was more than merely semantic.

51. For example, Article 15 of the East China Rent Reduction regulations stated: "Protect industry and trade, including those industrial and commercial enterprises engaged in by landlords and old-style rich peasants."

52. For an exposition of this policy, see Liu Shao-ch'i's report "On the Agrarian Reform Law," pp. 71–75.

53. *Agrarian Reform Law*, p. 3.

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In the Agrarian Reform Law the relevant section stated that:

> If the portion of land rented out by rich peasants of a semi-landlord type exceeds in size the area tilled by themselves and by their hired labour the land rented out should be requisitioned.[54]

The equivalent passage in the ECMA document was:

> In requisitioning land rented out by rich peasants of a semi-landlord type in the new areas, if the land cultivated by a rich peasant himself and by hired labour is smaller than the average per capita amount of land available for a particular area, then he should be permitted to retain an amount of land (including that cultivated by himself) equivalent to the average per capita for the area.[55]

Apparently, what this amounted to was the adoption of a different criterion for requisitioning rich peasants' land in the two cases. The assumption of the national law was that rich peasants should be subject to dispossession on the basis of the degree of exploitation practised by them (defined in terms of the amount of land rented out) and without reference to the size of their own operational holdings vis-à-vis those of other peasants. The import was (as one should expect) that the rights of rich peasants should be upheld and their land expropriated only in rather special circumstances. By contrast, the wording of the East China regulations made the position of the rich peasants more ambiguous since their status was related not just to their exploitative role, but also, more haphazardly, to the relationship between the size of their holdings and that of other peasants. This could only increase their vulnerability, for the amount of land managed personally by a rich peasant was likely to be greater than the average per capita arable area of any locality.

If this interpretation is correct the difference in wording is an interesting reflection of some of the limitations on land reform in the East China region. The economic benefits of land reallocation depended on the average amount of land available to each peasant. One of the features of East China agriculture was a high man-land ratio – and so a correspondingly high demand for confiscated land. Given that the amount of land that could be taken from landlords was fixed and that there was little possibility of extending the arable area, the only way of obtaining more land for reallocation was by encroaching upon that owned by the rich peasants.

Clearly then, conditions in East China were sufficiently distinctive to require changes in emphasis and revisions of some parts of the Agrarian Reform Law. Nevertheless, the East China regulations remained essentially moderate and pragmatic. Confiscation and reallocation should cause as little disruption as possible. If the poor and middle peasants were to be the real beneficiaries of land reform, inter-

54. *Ibid.*
55. *Ts'ai-cheng ching-chi fa-ling hui-pien*, Vol. 2, pp. 1976–996.

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

ference with the rich peasant economy was to be kept to a minimum. In certain circumstances even the interests of the landlords were to be protected. In the agricultural sector every effort should be made to ensure that land reform preparations did not interfere with production operations.

This emphasis on caution deserves special mention in view of the very different tone of the directive, calling for an acceleration of the land reform movement, promulgated by the East China Branch of the CCP little more than a week after the publication of the land reform regulations themselves.[56] Hitherto the approach to institutional change had been one of gradualism: where conditions permitted, land confiscation and distribution were to take place during the winter of 1950–51; but if preparations were not sufficiently advanced, they were to be postponed until the following winter or even later. Now, however, the new directive demanded that except for parts of Fukien and North Anhwei[57] "... the whole of the East China region should strive to basically complete land reform by April, 1951."[58]

This change in pace was reflected in the plans for North and South Kiangsu and I shall examine the reasons for it in more detail when I come to discuss land reform in these areas. For the present it is enough to note that the East China authorities attributed the decision to China's recent involvement in the Korean War.[59] China was coming under attack from the United States and its allies and "... inside and outside the country counter-revolutionary elements are intensifying their subversive activities."[60] Moreover, it was a matter of serious concern that despite East China's strategic defensive position "... imperialist forces and Kuomintang remnants ..." had still not been entirely eliminated from the area.[61] It was therefore argued that only if land reform were speeded up and rapidly completed could the earlier achievements be consolidated and any new eventualities be forestalled.

But pressing though these external factors may have been, it is more likely that the critical state of the land reform campaign itself was the true reason for the revised plans. In November 1950 a conference called to discuss the progress of the campaign had already referred to difficulties that had emerged. Landlords had not been slow to use the moderate tone of earlier directives to their own advantage and had allegedly engaged in a variety of sabotage activities, including the trans-

56. On Completing Land Reform Ahead of Time, in *ibid.* pp. 1996–998.

57. North Anhwei had been particularly hard-hit by flooding.

58. "Land reform in East China to be accelerated," *Shanghai News*, 16 December 1950, translated in *Survey of the China Mainland Press* (Hong Kong), No. 35 (21 December 1950), pp. 7–8.

59. China entered the Korean War in October 1950.

60. *Ts'ai-cheng ching-chi fa-ling hui-pien*, Vol. 2.

61. *Ibid.*

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

fer of land, destruction of property and arson.[62] They had committed murders and beatings and were involved in various subversive activities designed to undermine government authority. The situation was exacerbated by the failure of cadres to implement land reform properly: some were accused of "commandism" while others were criticized for their vacillating and careless attitudes.

Clearly the situation was serious enough to warrant a change in the time-table for land reform.[63] This was the basic decision taken at the November conference and it was echoed in the new tone of the December directive. In contrast to the earlier emphasis on conciliation the new document was more vituperative, returning to the more extreme language of the years immediately before 1949. Increasing reliance was placed on mass mobilization and class-struggle as the keys to eliminating the "feudal power" of the landlords. It was in this atmosphere that land reform in East China proceeded to its conclusion.[64]

4. *Land Reform in North Kiangsu*

Preparations got under way in the newly liberated areas of North Kiangsu in the spring of 1950 and by summer some 11,000 cadres had been trained in readiness for the coming campaigns.[65] They were sent throughout the region to co-ordinate land reform and production relief work. They conducted propaganda, set up Peasant Associations and strengthened the organizational base in the countryside[66]; at subsequent conferences they discussed and analysed their experience.

62. In order to bring these "lawless landlords" under control, the ECMA had in October promulgated its Provisional Regulations for Controlling Lawless Landlords in East China.

63. An interesting phenomenon of this period was the large amount of space in newspapers and other publications devoted to refuting the proposition that "there is no feudalism in Kiangnan" (*Chiang-nan wu feng-chien*). Special treatment of the large numbers of landlords with industrial and commercial interests seems to have given rise to the belief that rural conditions in Kiangnan were somehow different from those elsewhere in China – that landlordism was in fact less feudal and more progressive. The implications of such an argument were far-reaching, for they suggested that land reform might take place more peacefully and with less emphasis on class struggle.

64. Some indication of the effect upon land reform of the "new line" can be seen from a report which appeared in March 1951. It stated that the original plan was that an area of East China containing an agricultural population of 47 millions should complete land reform during the winter and spring of 1950–51. Yet by March 1951 land reform had been fully implemented in an area containing 66 million peasants (40% more than the original target). If the "old-liberated" areas were also included, the figure rose to 100 millions. See Liu Jui-lung, "Kuan-yü Hua-tung t'u-ti kai-ko kung-tso ti pao-kao" ("Report on land reform work in East China"), *Hsin-hua*, 21 March 1951, p. 2

65. "Su-pei t'u-ti kai-ko chi-pen wan-ch'eng" ("Land reform has basically been completed in North Kiangsu"), *Su-pei*, 31 May 1951, p. 1.

66. In "The newly liberated areas of North Kiangsu are vigorously creating the conditions for land reform" (*ibid.* 19 October 1951, p. 1) it was stated that

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During August and September small areas were chosen for the implementation of land reform on an experimental basis, and between August and the end of October such trials were conducted in 43 "representative" *hsiang*. Progress was slow and cautious, in accordance with the current ECMA directives. In November land distribution began to get under way over a wider area of North Kiangsu: by the end of the month preparations were basically completed and in the two southern-most special districts (Nan-t'ung and T'ai-chou), 146 *hsiang* were reported to have completed the confiscation and reallocation of land.[67]

The reports on which this chronological account is based nowhere suggest that preparatory work had gone other than smoothly and according to plan. Another article which appeared a little later is therefore of special interest for the evidence it gives of outstanding problems.[68] It revealed that two factors were threatening the future progress of land reform. The first (also noted in ECMA documents) was inadequate mass mobilization: landlords' subversive activities continued unchecked and peasants in some areas were even showing "boundless leniency" towards those who were guilty of such crimes. As a result, despite the regulations designed to control landlord subversion, opposition by this class continued to undermine the movement.[69]

The second problem arose out of the excessive demands of the Peasant Associations and their tendency towards "close-door sectarianism." This was doubtless partly responsible for the ineffectiveness of mass mobilization in some areas, for it was admitted that the adoption of membership criteria that were too restrictive had alienated peasants whose support was urgently needed for the successful implementation of land reform.

It was at this point, against the background of the Korean War and growing internal difficulties, that the North Kiangsu administration issued an order to accelerate land reform. It is interesting that this directive gave more attention to the immediate problems being encountered in the agricultural sector than to the potential threat posed by the international situation, supporting the earlier proposition that the new sense of urgency was primarily the product of endogenous

by the end of August 1950, 512 *hsiang* (76% of the total in this area) had established "peasant organizations" (*nung-hui tsu-chih*).

67. "Land reform has basically been completed in North Kiangsu."

68. "Lao-ch'ü chieh-shu t'u-kai kung-tso ta-pu wan-ch'eng, hsin-ch'ü t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung chin-chang chin-hsing" ("Land reform work is mostly completed in the old areas. In the new areas the land reform movement is moving ahead as a matter of urgency"), *ibid.* 10 December 1950, p. 2.

69. Accounts of the sabotage activities of the "lawless landlords" can be found in *Su-pei* during early November: see, for example, "Pu-fa ti-chu p'o-huai t'u-ti kai-ko" ("Lawless landlords are sabotaging land reform"), *ibid.* 1 November 1950, p. 2.

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factors. Significantly, it was emphasized that " . . . all levels of leadership must recognize the new character and new methods of land reform under the changed circumstances. They must beware of and overcome old, narrow-minded ideas of empiricism. . . ." [70] It was planned that during the winter of 1950–51, 75 per cent of the new areas would complete land reform, leaving the remaining 25 per cent to do so during the spring of 1951. In other words, it was now anticipated that land reform in North Kiangsu would be completed within about four months.

The land reform regulations themselves were published on 18 December.[71] They were set out in three sections corresponding to the " old liberated," the " rehabilitated " and the " newly liberated " areas of North Kiangsu. In the first, where CCP control had been maintained during the middle and late 1940s, land had already been confiscated and redistributed, and the main consideration was to guarantee the ownership rights of the peasant recipients and ensure that no attempt was made to deprive them of their land. That it was thought necessary to legislate for such protection is significant, for it was made clear in a later part of the regulations that such illegal confiscation had resulted in the dispossession of *middle* peasants.[72]

Other provisions dealt with the distribution of land and other resources that had been confiscated but not yet distributed. Priority was to be given to poor peasants, demobilized soldiers and unemployed workers from the cities, but special attention was also drawn to " . . . middle peasants who have been wrongly attacked . . . [and] . . . those rich peasants and landlords who have too little land and are unable to make a living." [73] Where too much land had been reallocated, further redistribution might take place on condition that the peasant voluntarily disclaimed his rights to the relevant piece of land. All other unresolved problems were to be settled in accordance with the principles of benefiting production and promoting social unity.

The rehabilitated areas were those in which some agrarian reform had been carried out during the 1940s but where subsequent reoccupation by Kuomintang forces had enabled landlords and rich peasants to recover their land and other resources. The December regulations abrogated all illegal acquisitions of this nature and called for the confiscation of any land (or other resources) subject to expropriation but still retained. Land taken forcibly from peasants was to be recovered and all sales or transfers of land transacted by landlords were declared null and void. Any losses suffered by the peasants on account of such transactions were to be borne by the landlords.

70. " Land reform work is mostly completed in the old areas."

71. Su-pei hsing-cheng-ch'ü t'u-ti kai-ko ch'ü-t'i shih-shih pan-fa (Specific Methods for Implementing Land Reform in the Administrative Region of North Kiangsu), *Su-pei*, 18 December 1950, p. 1.

72. And presumably rich peasants too.

73. Specific Methods for Implementing Land Reform, Article 3 (i).

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Similar provisions applied to rich peasants who had used the Kuomintang occupation during the late 1940s as an opportunity to take back their lost wealth.

The provisions for the newly liberated areas largely followed the principles laid down in the Agrarian Reform Law and the ECMA directive. Landlords were to receive the same amount of land as other peasants. Rich peasants could retain small amounts of rented-out land as long as there was sufficient to meet the demands of the poor peasants and hired agricultural labourers. But if this condition were not met, part or all of such land could be requisitioned.

Of considerable interest was the rule governing the reallocation of draft animals. The distinction between agricultural and non-agricultural use was again adopted as the criterion for confiscation, but a qualification was added to the effect that where the production requirements of a locality called for a greater or smaller supply of draft animals, the relevant ECMA provision could be ignored as long as permission was so granted by the North Kiangsu administration. In other words, animals originally used for non-agricultural purposes might be allocated to peasants for agricultural work. It seems clear that this less restrictive attitude towards the confiscation of draft animals was a reflection of their serious shortage in the region.

The final substantive article dealt with land in the "new" areas that had been transferred or dispersed by landlords but which was subject to confiscation. As a general principle Article Eight of the Agrarian Reform Law was cited,[74] but in order to meet the special circumstances of North Kiangsu, supplementary provisions were added. For example, in the interests of production, peasants who were entitled to land and had already received some through transactions with landlords were allowed to keep it. However, cash received by the landlords as a result of such sales was to be surrendered and distributed among the peasants. In those cases where a *hsien* government had granted land to a peasant since Liberation, care was to be taken during the reallocation process to protect the cultivator, even if his land was, strictly speaking, scheduled for redistribution. Finally, all sales of land between peasants were to be legally recognized as binding as long as they left no peasant with less arable land than the average for the locality.

It is noteworthy that the generally conciliatory tone of the North Kiangsu regulations is more reminiscent of the spirit of the earlier directives than those of the later period, with all its attendant problems. Certainly the urgency of the recent call for an acceleration of the

74. "Transfer or disposal after the liberation of the locality by sale, mortgage, gift or any other means, of any land which should be confiscated or requisitioned . . . shall be declared null and void. Such land should be included in the land to be redistributed. But if peasants who bought such land or took mortgages on such land will thereby suffer any considerable loss, measures should be worked out for proper compensation." *Agrarian Reform Law*, pp. 3–4.

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campaign is entirely absent from the document. Indeed, it is characterized more by those very "narrow-minded ideas of empiricism" that had come under attack only a week before. Whatever the reason for this discrepancy,[75] it is clear that even at the time of their publication the official guidelines for the implementation of land reform in North Kiangsu were already being rapidly superseded by the course of events.

Between December 1950 and March 1951 the confiscation and reallocation of land was basically completed. A report made by the vice-chairman of the North Kiangsu Land Reform Committee some months later looked back upon this period as one of untroubled progress:

> The government adopted urgent measures, gave support to the peasants' righteous struggle, set up People's Courts and brought lawless landlords under control. The movement merged with the "Resist-America, Support-Korea" and counter-revolutionary campaigns and the enthusiasm of the masses reached unprecedented heights. Blazing like fire set to a dry tinder, the struggle systematically unfolded to become the high-tide of the anti-feudal mass movement.[76]

At the end of 1951 this optimistic assessment may have seemed justified. However, a more revealing account published shortly after land distribution had ended shows clearly that the final stages of land reform were not so trouble-free.[77] Erroneous tendencies among both cadres and peasants persisted and, most serious of all, landlords continued actively to oppose the new policies. The slaughter of draft animals and the destruction of farm tools occurred frequently. Both were vital factors in the agricultural sector and the potential effect on production of a reduction in their numbers was very serious. There were reports, too, of landlords concealing arms, murdering peasants and infiltrating local organizations. In a village of Sui-ning *hsien*, a landlord murdered one of his permanent hired labourers for fear that this peasant would disclose where he had hidden some silver dollars and opium. Another landlord was reported to have bribed a work brigade with a payment of 2·4 million *yüan*.[78]

Such incidents continued well after the completion of land reallocation. As late as August 1951 there was talk of a resurgence of "lawless landlords."[79] Their recovery of confiscated land was blamed on the vacillating attitudes and indifference displayed by cadres. Concealment of land posed another problem: for example, an investigation of a village in T'ai-hsing *hsien* revealed that more than 141 *mou* of land had been

75. An obvious explanation would be that the rules governing the implementation of land reform were passed some time in advance of their official publication – as had been the case with the rent reduction regulations (see above, note 34).

76. Kao Feng, "Report on land reform work in North Kiangsu."

77. "Land reform has basically been completed in North Kiangsu."

78. *Ibid.*

79. "Pu-fa ti-chu fan-kung fu-p'i" ("Counterattacks and resurgence of lawless landlords"), *Su-pei*, 16 August 1951.

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successfully hidden from the authorities, representing 9·6 per cent of the total arable area.[80] Most astonishing of all, in some areas landlords were still secretly collecting rents.

Despite such difficulties land reform was gradually wound up. After confiscation and redistribution, title deeds were issued to the new owners of land. In view of the clearly expressed intention to move towards a socialized agriculture, such acts may seem to have been little more than empty gestures; but for peasants who acquired land of their own for the first time, they doubtless had very real significance. However, perhaps the single most important fact was that by the end of 1951, even if their resistance had not been wholly extinguished, the economic base of the landlords had been destroyed and a new class of small owner-occupiers was emerging.

5. *Land Reform in South Kiangsu*

The Chinese Communist forces crossed the Yangtze in April 1949 and completed the liberation of South Kiangsu by the beginning of June. During these months priority was given to bringing the military situation under control and normalizing conditions in the cities – a particularly important task because of the region's advanced industrial sector. By contrast, rural work was neglected and landlords and remnants of Kuomintang forces continued to create disorder in the villages.[81] The situation was aggravated by natural disasters which caused flooding on more than a million *mou* of arable land. The overall effect of these factors was to create growing discontent among the peasants in the summer of 1949.

Gradually, however, the precarious situation was stabilized: order was largely restored in the villages, the Party organization was strengthened and activists began to emerge from among the peasants. In July emphasis shifted from the cities to the countryside and cadres were sent down to mobilize the peasants. Rural work corps (*nung-ts'un kung-tso t'uan*) or work brigades (*kung-tso tui*) were set up in every *hsien* and membership of the Peasant Associations swiftly reached over 160,000. By the end of August conditions were ready for the preparatory stages of land reform to go ahead.

As propaganda work advanced and Party control extended down to the village level, the peasants seem to have been increasingly won over to the new policies. Action continued to be taken against Kuomintang sympathizers, anti-flood measures were successfully adopted and some of the problems associated with the failure of the autumn crop were overcome. The prime consideration in October was production work and the maintenance of the sown area; throughout November and December the "autumn levy" (the acquisition of grain by the state

80. "Push ahead with the work of regulating the land," *ibid.* 14 May 1951, p. 2.
81. See "The peasant movement in South Kiangsu since Liberation."

https://doi.org/10.1017/S0305741000033683 Published online by Cambridge University Press

for storage and distribution) was completed.[82] By the end of the year Peasant Association membership was over two and a quarter millions (about 22 per cent of the agricultural population).

Yet it was freely admitted that there were many deficiencies in the peasant movement.[83] Attention was drawn, for example, to its uneven progress: in some areas mass mobilization was well under way, but in others landlord power remained intact. A major problem was peasant reluctance to speak out against the landlords, so enabling the latter to use a variety of familiar subterfuges to escape rent reduction. They wept false tears and feigned poverty to their tenants, made loans to peasants on terms that provided them with a substitute for the rent that had been deducted; they used the legal wording of official directives to their personal advantage, exaggerated cadres' shortcomings and even threatened to take back land which they rented out.[84] In some instances they managed to manipulate whole bodies, such as Peasant Associations, for their own ends.

That such problems existed is hardly surprising. If they had arisen in North Kiangsu, how much more likely were they to do so in the more recently liberated south. Both economically and socially, South Kiangsu was a more complex area, above all because of its highly developed industrial and urban sectors.[85] A corollary was that thorough preparatory work and a gradualist approach towards land reform were even more essential than they had been in the north of the province.

A directive published towards the end of March 1950 gave the first indication of the planned schedule for land reform in South Kiangsu.[86] It stated that where preparatory work had been fully carried out and the peasants were properly organized, the redistribution of confiscated land should begin after the autumn harvest (1950). Where these conditions were not fulfilled, reallocation was to be postponed until after the autumn harvest of 1951. Meanwhile, investigations of local conditions, the drafting of plans for each area, propaganda and trial land reform on a representative basis should simultaneously get under way. A policy of gradualism was rigidly upheld.

The co-ordination of these tasks with production work in the fields was of special importance, for as one of the richest agricultural regions

82. But not without difficulty: see *ibid.* where it was reported that during the autumn levy, landlords transferred property and wealth and concealed and divided their land in an effort to escape their obligations. 83. *Ibid.*

84. *Ibid.* It is worth mentioning that talk of cadres' shortcomings was not pure fantasy, as witness the criticism of "formalism," "close-door sectarianism" and other erroneous tendencies.

85. "Kuan-yü Su-nan hsing-cheng-ch'ü kung-tso ch'ing-k'uang ti pao-kao" ("Report on the work situation in the administrative region of South Kiangsu") (*ibid.* 6 February 1950, p. 1) emphasized the uniqueness of South Kiangsu's economy.

86. Kuan-yü t'u-ti kai-ko chun-pai kung-tso ti chih-shih (Directive on Preparations for Land Reform), *ibid.* 23 March 1951, p. 1.

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in the whole country, it was essential to maintain levels of production in Kiangnan. It is significant that where land distribution was scheduled to begin in autumn 1950, cadres were exhorted to make sure it was completed before the spring-ploughing period of the following year. Nor was the emphasis on the need to press ahead with the grain levy accidental. In addition, the effects of the natural disasters were still a recent memory and one article pointed out that any delay in spring ploughing would affect the autumn harvest and so prolong the consequences of the disasters.[87] In some severely hit areas the situation remained critical and it was " . . . not simply a question of how to solve the problem of livelihood, but of how to save lives." [88]

Throughout spring and summer the movement proceeded according to plan. Detailed studies were made of the land situation and the problems of agrarian reform in South Kiangsu. By the end of July, 3,600 cadres had been trained and a further 20,000 were anticipated by the autumn harvest.[89] Peasant Associations were established in every *hsiang* and they took the lead in production work and relief operations. At the same time, experimental work was being undertaken in representative villages by the work brigades and this was expected to be extended during August.[90]

Preparations were in fact sufficiently well advanced to permit the implementation of land reform in accordance with the original plans, and in August the South Kiangsu administration reaffirmed its decision to start confiscation and reallocation after the autumn harvest.[91] In normal circumstances this would hardly have merited attention; yet it is precisely that the original plan was being adhered to that is so interesting, for exactly a month later a new directive announced the intention to *complete* land reform in South Kiangsu during the winter and spring of 1950–51.[92]

87. " Mu-ch'ien Su-nan sheng-ch'an chiu-tsai ti ch'ing-shih ho jen-wu " (" The current situation and the tasks of production relief in South Kiangsu "), *ibid.* 11 April 1950, p. 1.

88. *Ibid.*

89. " I-chiu-wu-ling nien chang-pan-nien ti Su-nan hsing-cheng kung-tso " (" Administrative work in South Kiangsu in the first half of 1950 "), *ibid.* 28 July 1950, p. 1.

90. This is not to suggest that all the former difficulties had been overcome – in particular, landlord opposition continued on a wide scale. See " Pu-fa ti-chu p'o-huai t'u-kai fa-ling " (" Lawless landlords break the Land Reform Law "), *ibid.* 21 August 1950, p. 1, and " Chen-chiang chuan-ch'ü pu-fa ti-chu p'o-huai sheng-ch'an p'o-huai t'u-kai " (" Lawless landlords in Chinkiang special district are undermining production and sabotaging land reform "), *ibid.* 22 September 1950, p. 1. The landlord problem in South Kiangsu was more intractable than in the north because of the large numbers that owned industrial and commercial enterprises.

91. " Ch'iu-shou hou shih-hsing t'u-ti kai-ko " (" Implement land reform after the autumn harvest "), *ibid.* 7 August 1950, p. 1

92. " Chüeh-i tung-yüan Su-nan ch'üan-t'i nung-min chin-tung ming-ch'un wan-ch'eng t'u-ti kai-ko " (" Decision to mobilize all the peasants of South Kiangsu to complete land reform this winter and next spring "), *ibid.* 7 September 1950, p. 1.

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This decision was the outcome of a specially convened conference on land reform held in Wusih between 2 and 6 September. Opening speeches on the current situation and future tasks were made by Ch'en P'i-hsien and Ou-yang Hui-lin[93] and their reports were subsequently discussed by the delegates. Denunciation of landlords occupied much of the conference: there was constant reference to their exploitation of peasants and to the responsibility they bore for rural poverty.[94] Demands were made to curb their destructive and subversive activities and bring them under control.[95]

Of the four resolutions passed on the final day, the most interesting was that calling for the completion of land reform within about six months.[96] At first glance this may seem to have been less than surprising: did it not after all parallel the similar decision taken by both the ECMA and North Kiangsu administration? However, in both these cases it will be recalled that the need to accelerate the campaign was attributed to the dangerous political situation created by the Korean War. What is particularly noteworthy about the South Kiangsu resolution is that it was taken at the beginning of September 1950, a full three months before North Kiangsu took similar action and before China entered the war.

What was the reason for the sudden change of plan? The preoccupation of the delegates with the problems caused by continuing landlord opposition to rural policies suggests the answer, for it is likely that these difficulties, combined with deficiencies in peasant mass mobilization, had led to an impasse which threatened the future of the land reform movement. The way out was to intensify propaganda work, emphasize class-struggle and radicalize policy in the hope that the difficulties could be overcome by pushing ahead more rapidly.

Support for this interpretation is not only provided by the tone and content of the conference reports themselves, but also by an analysis of the revised plans for land reform which were published

93. Ch'en P'i-hsien was the secretary of the Party Committee of the CCP (South Kiangsu branch). Ou-yang Hui-lin was a member of the ECMA Land Reform Committee. The text of Ou-yang's report can be found in *ibid.* 3 September 1950, p. 1.

94. The supposed relationship between tenancy and rural poverty was not always understood by the peasants. Some contemporary reports even suggest that they were taken in by landlords' protestations that they (the peasants) owed their very existence to the landlords' generosity in renting out land.

95. See especially "Ko-ti tai-piao k'ung-su ti-chu chieh-chi po-hsüeh tsui-o chieh-lu pu-fa ti-chu p'o-huai t'u-ti kai-ko tsui-hsing" ("Representatives from all areas accuse the landlord class of exploitation and unmask the criminal activities of lawless landlords against land reform"), *ibid.* 5 September 1950, p. 1.

96. "On mobilizing the peasant masses to complete land reform in South Kiangsu this winter and next spring," *Su-nan*, 3 September 1950, p. 1. The resolution was in many ways a simple endorsement of Ou-yang Hui-lin's speech calling for an acceleration of land reform.

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the same day.[97] The whole force of this directive was that the future of agrarian reform in South Kiangsu depended on the class-struggle against the landlords. Antagonism between peasant and landlord reflected the relationship between the elimination of "feudal" exploitation and the liberation of rural productive forces and their development of agricultural production. Class differentiation was of course a cornerstone of land reform policy, but the conciliatory spirt of earlier directives had tended to underplay its importance. Now, however, it was re-emphasized.[98] Thus, ". . . unless effective measures are taken . . . social order will be destroyed and it will be difficult to implement land reform in an orderly and steady manner. If lawless landlords are not dealt with strictly, the people's leniency towards those landlords who do uphold the law cannot be shown."[99]

The proceedings of a second conference provide further evidence to support this analysis. This was the Second Plenum of the First Session of the Conference of People's Representatives from All Levels of South Kiangsu,[100] also held in Wusih and formally opened on 5 September 1950 by Ch'en P'i-hsien.

The speeches made by the various delegates give a clear picture of how the land reform situation in South Kiangsu was viewed at this time and how seriously the threat posed by landlord opposition was taken. Virtually all the speakers repeated the accusation that the landlord class was the root cause of peasant poverty, backwardness and oppression, and followed the example of the earlier conference in calling for strict measures to control and stop its criminal activities.[101]

But even more interesting were the attacks on the still prevalent notion that "Kiangnan isn't feudal." The argument behind this was that since urbanization and industrialization had reached an advanced stage, with many landlords engaged in industrial and commercial activities, the "feudal" characteristics of landlordism north of the Yangtze were absent in the region. Moreover, not only were there no "big" landlords in South Kiangsu but landlord numbers in general were much fewer. Such attitudes were fostered by the national and regional directives, for both had emphasized the need to treat land-

97. "Su-nan ti-i-chieh nung-min tai-piao ta-hui t'ung-kuo ti ssu-hsiang chüeh-i" ("The four decisions taken by the South Kiangsu first peasant representative conference"), *ibid.* 7 September 1950, p. 1.

98. See also the second resolution passed at the conference "Kuan-yü chin-hou nung-min hsüeh-hui kung-tso ti chüeh-i" ("On the future work of the Peasant Associations"), *ibid.*

99. "Pa Su-nan nung-tai ta-hui ti ching-shen kuan-ch'e tao nung-min ch'ün-chung-chung ch'ü!" ("Thoroughly inculcate the spirit of the South Kiangsu conference of peasant representatives into the peasant masses!"), *ibid.*

100. Su-nan ke-chieh jen-min tai-piao hui-i shou-ch'u erh-tz'u ch'üan-hui.

101. See, for example, the bitter attack by Chang Yün-hsi in "Ko-chieh tai-piao tsai ta-hui-shang ti fa-yen" ("Speeches by various representatives at the conference"), *Su-nan*, 14 September 1950, p. 2; also the speech of Chiao K'ang-shen, *ibid.*

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lords with industrial and commercial interests as a special category.[102] From this it was but a short way to the conclusion that landlord exploitation south of the Yangtze was less severe than elsewhere and that land reform policies should be accordingly modified.[103]

The speech made by Chou Mei-ch'u was clearly designed to redress the balance.[104] He pointed out that such slogans as "Kiangnan isn't feudal," "there are no big landlords in Kiangnan" or "Kiangnan doesn't have tenant households, only guest households" continued to be disseminated in every *hsien* and were particularly prevalent in the cities. Others argued that landlords were primarily engaged in activities other than those connected with the ownership of land and that, in any case, their holdings did not extend to tens of thousands of *mou* as they did in the north of the province. All this, said Chou, was mistaken: subversive acts had taken place throughout South Kiangsu and the only difference between landlords north and south of the Yangtze was that in the south they were a good deal more cunning and adept in concealing their true character.

Ou-yang Hui-lin took the argument a stage further.[105] He said that the assertion "Kiangnan isn't feudal" was being supplanted by an allegation that land for reallocation was inadequate because of the heavy population pressure upon scarce arable land. The implication was that land reform could only result in the emergence of farms of uneconomic size. Ou-yang's rebuttal of this argument is of the greatest significance, for it provided one of the few instances in which the economic aspects of land reform were discussed. He pointed out that the arable area of South Kiangsu could provide each member of the agricultural population with a little over two *mou* of cultivable land. Presumably, he considered this a viable economic unit. However, the figure was misleading since in some densely populated districts the amount of land available for reallocation was less than one *mou* per head. Ou-yang recognized this but refused to find it economically disadvantageous, arguing instead that ". . . as long as land reform is

102. Even in September 1950, the question of protecting trade and industry continued to concern some of the conference delegates. P'ing Hsiao-chung, a representative of trade and industry, spoke of the important inter-relationship between agriculture and industry and trade. Agriculture, he said, provided both the raw materials and market for the industrial sector, but only through industrialization could the problem of rural poverty be solved. The Agrarian Reform Law's emphasis on the need to protect industry and trade reflected the importance of this relationship and was quite in accordance with the objective situation. See *ibid.*

103. See also the attack by Ch'en Yün-ke on those people who took the attitude that peasant demands were wrong and who sided with the landlords (*ibid.*). Also that of Huang Li-yeh who called on the conference to take the standpoint of the peasants, not the landlords ("Speeches by various representatives at the conference," *ibid.* 15 September 1950, p. 6).

104. "Speeches by various representatives," *ibid.* 14 September 1950, p. 2.

105. "Speeches by various representatives," *ibid.* 15 September 1950, p. 5. At this conference Ou-yang represented the South Kiangsu Peasant Associations.

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implemented thoroughly, even if peasants with little or no land only get a small plot, they'll still be happy." [106] And again, " . . . as long as the feudal exploitative system of the landlord class is eliminated and the peasants are made owners of their own land, the production enthusiasm of the peasants can still be raised even if they get only a small amount of land. Even on a tiny plot, they'll still be able to achieve a bumper harvest." [107] But he did admit that land reform alone could not eliminate rural poverty and that after reallocation had taken place peasants would have to carry out farm improvements, adopting deeper ploughing and more intensive cultivation, applying more fertilizer, using better seeds and organizing mutual aid.

Ou-yang's speech was an indication that however dominant political factors underlying land reform may have been, economic considerations were not wholly ignored. On the other hand, his vigorous defence of the positive economic effects suggests that not everyone shared his optimistic assessment of rural policies. More specifically, it seems clear that some were concerned that the institutional changes would have only a marginal impact on economic productivity because of South Kiangsu's high man-land ratio. How far Ou-yang Hui-lin was justified in his faith in the economic efficacy of land reform will become clearer when the economic implications of reallocation are considered in the second part of this article.

In accordance with the revised plans, the confiscation and redistribution of land got under way in South Kiangsu after the autumn harvest and, by early November 1950, it was already anticipated that the entire agricultural population would have completed land reform by the following spring.[108]

The decision to accelerate land reform in the north had preceded the publication of the formal regulations for land reform by about a week; in the south the discrepancy was much greater. The first Wusih conference in early September had already determined that land distribution should be completed by spring 1951 and in its emphasis on class struggle had clearly moved away from the conciliation and pragmatism of the parent Agrarian Reform Law and other regional directives. Yet paradoxically, the land reform regulations for South Kiangsu, which appeared almost three months later,[109] far from upholding the new line, seemed to return to the spirit of the earlier phase of the campaign.

Thus, although dispossession of the landlords remained the main-

106. *Ibid.*

107. *Ibid.*

108. " Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko yün-tung chi-chiang chu-pu chan-k'ai " (" The future stages of development of the land reform movement in South Kiangsu "), *ibid.* 4 November 1950, p. 1.

109. Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko shih-shih pan-fa (Methods of Implementing Land Reform in South Kiangsu), promulgated by the Office of the People's Administration of South Kiangsu, in *ibid.* 28 November 1950, p. 1.

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spring of the movement, the regulations called for a degree of caution in its implementation. Land which the landlords themselves had brought under cultivation since 1949 was to remain untouched and members of landlord families were to be compensated for any agricultural work they had carried out. They were also to receive land for their own use equal to the average per capita amount available in the locality.[110]

There was also continuing concern that industry and trade in South Kiangsu should be protected:

> Other properties of landlords, including their industrial and commercial enterprises, are not to be confiscated. This is definitely for the protection of industry and trade. Because large numbers of landlords simultaneously engage in industry and commerce south of the Yangtze, it is difficult within a short time to distinguish the other properties of landlords from their industrial and commercial enterprises. If these other landlord properties are confiscated, their industrial and commercial enterprises may also be affected. Naturally, such other properties of the landlords which are actually not connected with industry and trade may also be exempted from infringement due to this regulation. *This is against the interests of the peasants. However, in order to avoid confusion it is better to allow the landlords to keep these properties and enable them to invest in production.* This will be beneficial to society as a whole [emphasis added].[111]

These sentences are an admirable illustration of the conflict that the multiple objectives of land reform could give rise to; furthermore, in its willingness to sacrifice what might be called social justice in the broader interests of economic stability and growth, the passage reveals the extent of pragmatic concessions. Notwithstanding its appeal to the good of society as a whole, this was a clear statement of determination to sustain industry and trade even at the expense of forfeiting some of the basic aims of land reform. In any conflict between the interests of the peasants and those of the modern sector, priority should go to the latter.[112]

Differences in the wording of ECMA regulations and those of the central government had already indicated how the pressure of population on arable land in some areas could lead to a modification of the policy of " preserving the rich peasant economy." In the South Kiangsu regulations this point emerged more explicitly:

> With regard to large amounts of land rented out by rich peasants, even if the amount of such land does not exceed the area cultivated by themselves or with the help of hired labour, it may, if demands are so made by a

110. *Ibid.*

111. *Ibid.*

112. Specific provisions included the following: all landlord houses in cities and villages used directly for industrial and commercial activities (including those which had been rented out prior to the publication of the Agrarian Reform Law) were to be untouched. Confiscation of surplus buildings belonging to landlords could only take place after discussion at the *ch'ü* (" district ") level and after permission had been given to the *hsien* authorities, etc. See *ibid.* Articles 3, 4 and 5.

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majority of peasants and if the matter is sanctioned by this office [South Kiangsu administration], be partly or wholly requisitioned. . . .[113]

This was a clear departure from the Agrarian Reform Law which had implied that only land in excess of that cultivated by the rich peasants themselves or their hired labourers should be requisitioned.

The treatment of land which was divided into surface and sub-soil rights [114] was of particular importance in South Kiangsu. If such land were simply confiscated from the landlord (the owner of the sub-soil right) the result would be to penalize the tenant (the peasant holding the surface right but paying a rent to the sub-soil owner). Some way had therefore to be found of expropriating the landlord without expropriating the tenant. The problem had already been recognized by the Agrarian Reform Law which stated that "if the tiller possesses the surface rights of the land he rents, a portion of land equivalent to the price of the surface rights in that locality shall be reserved for him if the land is drawn upon for distribution." [115] This was essentially the solution adopted by the South Kiangsu authorities. Thus, "in adjusting land, the surface right of which has been rented out to tillers, a portion of land equal to the value of the surface right should be reserved for the tiller." [116] In other words, distribution was to take place in the usual way except that, because of his special status as owner and tenant on the same piece of land, the owner of the surface right was to receive an additional piece of land equal in value to that right. In effect, it was a move away from the normal principle governing distribution and was designed to achieve the twin aims of dispossession

113. *Ibid.*

114. The peculiar device whereby land was symbolically divided between the "surface right" (*t'ien-mien ch'üan*) and the "bottom right" (*t'ien-ti ch'üan*) was the origin of a particular form of tenancy in South Kiangsu mistakenly called "permanent tenancy." The owner of the bottom right was the title holder to the land and, as such, it was his name that was registered with the government and he who paid the land taxes. Although he was not allowed to cultivate the land (that privilege belonged to the owner of the surface right alone) he was permitted to collect rent from the cultivator of the soil. In other words, the holder of the bottom right was the landlord and the holder of the surface right, the tenant. The landlord could sell his bottom right (his claim on rent) but this in no way affected the right of the tenant to continue cultivating the soil. For his part, the tenant could farm the land himself, employ hired labour to do so or sub-lease the land to a third party and so simultaneously become landlord and tenant. The importance of this device is indicated by the fact that it existed in an area of South Kiangsu containing 10 million peasants (about 40% of the total agricultural population). However, distribution was not general and it was found in only 12 out of 25 *hsien*. It was most common in the east, occurred to a more limited extent in central South Kiangsu and was not found at all in the west. For further consideration of this phenomenon, see P'an and Ch'üan, *Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko fang-wen chi*, Chap. 3. Also Fei Hsiao-t'ung, *Peasant Life in China: A Field Study of Country Life in the Yangtze Valley* (London: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1939), Chap. XI, pp. 181–91, is of special interest.

115. *Agrarian Reform Law*, p. 5.

116. Methods of Implementing Land Reform in South Kiangsu.

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of landlord and protection of tenant (here represented by the surface owner).

November and December 1950 were the " high-tide " of land reform in South Kiangsu.[117] The evidence suggests that during this period there was something of a breakthrough in the campaign. One report indicated that until November insufficient mobilization of the peasants and the failure of the People's Courts to take strong action against the landlords left much of the initiative still in their hands.[118] Even where land had been reallocated, landlords found ways to take it back; and in parts of Wu *hsien* peasants dared not cultivate the land which they had been given. But by the end of November, landlord opposition had passed its peak and confiscation and reallocation of land made rapid progress.[119] By the middle of the following month, 1,157 *hsiang* were reported to have completed this work: 546 in Sung-chiang special district, 210 in Ch'ang-chou, 143 in Soochow, 126 in Chinkiang and 132 in Wusih *hsien*.[120] This represented 43 per cent of the 2,667 *hsiang* scheduled for land reform. Emphasis on class struggle continued and there were direct confrontations between landlords and peasants. In January 1951 meetings of peasant representatives were called at *ch'ü* and *hsiang* levels everywhere in order to oppose those landlords who were still against the movement, and a formal " struggle movement " was launched.[121] Material collected during this period became the evidence that was used at subsequent trials held by the People's Courts.

By 15 February land reallocation was completed in 1,983 *hsiang* in 12 *hsien* (114 *ch'ü*). Another 701 *hsiang* were in the process of implementing land reform and only 23 were encountering some delay.[122] It was now anticipated that the work of redistributing the confiscated land would be generally completed by the middle of March. Indeed, in the last week of that month, the *New China Daily* proclaimed in the title of one of its leading articles that, " Land reform [is] basically completed in South Kiangsu." [123]

In view of the speed with which land had been confiscated and redistributed it was perhaps inevitable that some problems should

117. " Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko kung-tso ti pao-kao " (" Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu "), made at the First Plenum of the Second Session of the South Kiangsu Conference of People's Representatives, *Su-nan*, 1 January 1952, pp. 2–3.

118. " Su-nan-ch'ü t'u-kai chi-pen wan-ch'eng " (" Land reform basically completed in South Kiangsu "), *Hsin-hua*, 21 March 1951, p. 2.

119. " Hua-tung t'u-kai yün-tung ch'üan-mien chan-k'ai " (" The land reform movement is advancing on a broad front throughout East China "), *Su-nan*, 12 December 1950, p. 1.

120. " Su-nan t'u-kai ch'üan-mien chan-k'ai " (" Land reform in South Kiangsu is advancing on a broad front "), *ibid.* 23 December 1950, p. 1.

121. This was the *shuo-li tou-cheng*.

122. " Su-nan t'u-ti kai-ko kung-tso ch'ing-k'uang " (" The situation regarding land reform work in South Kiangsu "), *Su-nan*, 18 April 1951, p. 2.

123. *Hsin-hua*, 21 March 1951.

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remain outstanding. Cadres were criticized for their haste and carelessness. Landlords still managed to escape the confines of their villages in large numbers.[124] In some areas dispossession only affected landlords' land, and draft animals, tools, surplus grain [125] and buildings were left untouched. In others, peasants complained that the landlords were still better off after land reform because of the large amounts of good land which they were allowed to keep. The most serious revelation was that in some districts only a mock land reform had taken place, the distribution of land and other factors remaining unchanged in real terms.[126]

Such problems must have occupied the attention of the cadres during the rest of 1951 when land reform entered its final stage. Checks were also made on the work that had been carried out and title deeds were issued to the new landowners. By mid-August these tasks had been completed in 383 *hsiang* and work was progressing rapidly in the remaining villages.[127] By the beginning of 1952 the land reform campaign was wound up in South Kiangsu.[128]

124. Statistics showed that 520 landlord households had escaped from villages in Wusih *hsien* and 391 in I-hsing *hsien*. See "P'i-p'ing lang-fei t'u-kai kuo-shih hsien-hsiang" ("Criticism of the wastage of the fruits of land reform"), *Su-nan*, 18 February 1951, p. 1.

125. Grain was distributed to the poor peasants for production purposes (for seed).

126. "Report on land reform work in South Kiangsu."

127. "San-pa-san-ko hsiang wan-ch'eng fa t'u-ti-cheng" ("Three hundred and eighty three *hsiang* have completed the work of issuing title deeds"), *Su-nan*, 13 August 1951, p. 1.

128. In the preceding pages the land reform has been considered in the general contexts of North and South Kiangsu. A slight qualification to these accounts is that land reform in the large city suburbs of South Kiangsu followed a slightly different chronology from that outlined above.

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